

1935–1944

AMERICAN READY-TO-WEAR

Following the invasion of Paris in June 1940, the rest of Europe and the United States were cut off from French couture for four years. During the previous decade, American fashion designers had begun to develop a distinctive style, focusing on easy-to-wear, modern clothing as opposed to the elaborate and elite confections of Paris. Practicality was one prominent characteristic, and resulted in the use of easy-care fabrics, adaptable styles, and capsule wardrobes with elements that could be interchanged. The need for simplicity required by mass-production was not seen as a hindrance but was used to advantage. The work of New York-based, ready-to-wear designers was promoted as symbolic of American values such as democracy, pioneer spirit, and a pragmatic approach to life. The creations of made-to-measure designers such as Valentina and Adrian, who continued in the couture tradition, were less aligned with national identity.



1935

Luncheon wear High society continued to wear different types of clothing at different times of day. This dress by Mme Clayton of New York is being modelled during a fashion benefit luncheon at New York's luxury Versailles Restaurant.

ON FIFTH AVENUE



The recognition of home-grown design talent in America depended heavily on the Fifth Avenue department store Lord & Taylor, particularly the promotional activities of Dorothy Shaver, who became the store's vice president in 1931. In 1932, at the height of the Great Depression, a series of window displays featured the work of New York designers rather than the manufacturers they worked for. A year later a press release extolled the output of what was called "The American Designers' Movement", and in 1938 the store inaugurated the annual \$1,000 Lord & Taylor American Design awards. In 1945 the store launched another campaign to promote "The American Look", a phrase they also copyrighted.



1937

Contrasts This witty design by Claire Potter incorporates a knitted collar and sleeves. Although Potter was known as a great colourist, she used a pared-down palette for this dress. Her designs emphasised the figure.



1938

Slip-on style This pleated version of one of Claire McCardell's most famous designs, the "Monastic" is made of open-weave wool. Zips on either side of the neck allow the dress to be slipped on; a wide belt provides the shape.